Conference of Children and Youth (COY)

Safeguarding Policy & Procedure

This Safeguarding Policy & Procedure sets out the standard of behaviours, responsibilities & practices everyone is expected to follow while participating in the Conference of Children and Youth (COY), & COY's commitments, standards & systems to ensure a safe, respectful, & inclusive environment for everyone.

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COY SAFEGUARDING POLICY & PROCEDURE

The standard of behaviours, responsibilities & practices everyone is expected to follow while participating in COY, & COY's commitments, standards & systems to ensure a safe, respectful, & inclusive environment for everyone.

STANDARD OF BEHAVIOUR	SAFEGUARDING POLICY	SAFEGUARDING PROCEDURE
Individual standards of behaviour, responsibilities, and practices all attendees are expected to follow at COY.	**COY's commitments** & minimum standards and safeguards put in place to prevent harm and protect everyone attending.	**How COY prevents, reports, responds, and follows up on safeguarding concerns** raised under the Safeguarding Policy and Standard of Behaviour.
1 - Dignity, Respect & Equality	**1 - An environment free from harassment and bullying in all forms**	**1 - PREVENT** • Event Safeguarding Risk Assessment • Pre-Event Checklist • Training • Safeguarding Team
2 - Inclusiveness, Diversity & Cultural Safety	**2 - Zero tolerance of any sexual misconduct**	
3 - Preventing Harassment, Bullying & Sexual Misconduct	**3 - Child safety**	**2 - REPORT** • Who can Report • What to Report • Reporting Channels • Confidentiality • Protection Against Retaliation
4 - Keeping Each Other Safe	**4 - A culturally safe environment**	
5 - Alcohol, Drugs & Substance Use	**5 - A space free from discrimination, safeguarding equality & inclusiveness**	**3 - RESPOND** • General response sequence • Immediate Safety Measures • Risk Rating & Triage • Concern-Specific Response Protocols
6 - Social Media & Digital Conduct	**6 - Mental health, wellbeing & psychosocial safety**	
7 - Undue Use of Information	**7 - Heat, dehydration & fatigue management**	
8 - Function Abuse	**8 - Rapid, appropriately-trained first aid**	**4 - FOLLOW-UP** • Outcome & follow-up support • Consequences of Violations • Reporting COY21 Safeguarding Outcomes to YOUNGO
9 - Taking Responsibility for the Bigger Picture	**9 - Zero tolerance of alcohol & drug use**	

PART 1 - OVERVIEW

1.1 | Purpose

This document sets out the commitments, standards and systems to ensure a safe, respectful and inclusive environment for everyone engaging in COY related settings, outlining:

- the standards of individual behaviour, responsibilities, and practices all attendees are expected to follow **(Standard of Behaviour)**, and
- the commitments & minimum standards and safeguards COY puts in place to prevent harm and protect everyone attending, with particular regard to children and others who need extra support. **(Safeguarding Policy).**
- the reporting, risk-assessment, and response systems that put those commitments into practice - how COY prevents, reports, responds, and follows up on safeguarding incidents **(Safeguarding Procedure).**

1.2 | Scope

This Safeguarding Policy & Procedure applies to every COY participant (including but not limited to; organisers, staff, volunteers, speakers, facilitators, delegates, partners, sponsors, exhibitors, contractors, media, and visitors) throughout the duration of COY (venues, accommodation, transport between COY-affiliated locations) and covers all related activities before, during and after the event, in person, online or hybrid. **It places obligations on the COY team, leaders, the Safeguarding Team & volunteers to administer & oversee its compliance.**

1.3 | Relationship to YOUNGO & UNFCCC Policies

YOUNGO's Principles, Code of Conduct, Safeguarding Policy & Child Safeguarding Policy set constituency-wide standards - this Safeguarding Policy & Procedure upholds and applies those standards to COY, setting out their on-the-ground, event-level application.

It is noted that these YOUNGO documents draw inspiration from existing similar documents including the UNFCCC's Code of Ethics of the elected and appointed Officers, Code of Conduct for Conferences, Meetings and Events, Guide for Presiding Officers, by CAN's Anti Bullying and Harassment Policy and Code of Conduct. However it is also important to note that the COY is not a UNFCCC Secretariat-organised event and hence the UN Department of Safety and Security resources and reporting mechanisms are not directly available or applicable for any COY engagements that occur outside of the green and blue zone during official COP and SB dates.

This Safeguarding Policy & Procedure is guided by the core principles of the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC) and internationally recognised child safeguarding standards.

1.4 Definitions

For the purposes of this Safeguarding Policy & Procedure:

- **Safeguarding:** refers to the measures and practices put in place to protect all participants from harm, abuse, exploitation, neglect, harassment, discrimination, and any form of inappropriate behaviour.
- **Child:** refers to any person under the age of 18 years, in accordance with the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child.
- **Cultural Safety:** An environment where a person's cultural identity, protocols and worldview are respected and not diminished.
- **Harassment:** means any unwelcome verbal, non-verbal, written, visual, or physical behaviour that intimidates, humiliates, threatens, or creates an offensive, hostile, or unsafe environment. Harassment includes but is not limited to offensive jokes, insults, or derogatory remarks; bullying, intimidation, or repeated unwanted behaviour; unwanted physical contact; offensive comments related to a person's identity or protected characteristics; stalking or persistent unwanted attention; and online harassment through messages, emails, social media, or virtual event platforms.
- **Sexual Misconduct:** includes any unwanted sexual behaviour, sexual harassment, sexual exploitation, coercion, inappropriate sexual comments or gestures, or any form of non-consensual sexual conduct.
- **Discrimination:** refers to unfair or unequal treatment of an individual based on characteristics such as age, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, disability, race, ethnicity, nationality, religion, culture, language, or any other protected characteristic.
- **Participant:** any individual (including but not limited to organizers, volunteers, staff members, speakers, facilitators, delegates, partners, sponsors, exhibitors, contractors, media personnel, and any other individuals) engaged in COY activities.
- **Psychosocial support:** Non-clinical emotional and social support (as distinct from medical/clinical mental health treatment).
- **Risk Rating:** The tiered assessment used to determine urgency and response.
- **Safeguarding Focal Point:** The named individual(s) accountable for receiving and triaging concerns on the day.
- **Survivor-centric approach:** considering and lawfully prioritising the needs, rights and wishes of survivors.

- **Trauma-informed approach:** recognising the prevalence and impact of trauma, and responding in ways that prioritise safety, choice, trust, power-sharing and empowerment for all people involved.
- **Psychosocial support:** Non-clinical emotional and social support (as distinct from medical/clinical mental health treatment).

PART 2 - STANDARD OF BEHAVIOUR

This Standard of Behaviour sets out the standards of individual behaviour, responsibilities, and practices all attendees are expected to follow at COY, complementary to the YOUNGO Code of Conduct.

2.1 | Standard 1: Dignity, Respect & Equality

Expected:

- We treat everyone with dignity, fairness & courtesy, regardless of age, race, gender identity, nationality, disability, sexual orientation, religion or any other status.
- We don't do anything that compromises the safety, wellbeing, or dignity of another person.
- We communicate respectfully, in person & on every digital platform connected to COY.

2.2 | Standard 2: Inclusiveness, Diversity & Cultural Safety

Expected:

- Value diversity, building an environment where people can disagree on ideas without disrespecting the person.
- Respect personal boundaries, privacy, and the right to give or withhold informed consent in every interaction.
- Honour the cultural protocols and practices of all participants, including Indigenous peoples.
- Treat flags, name plates, and any officially recognized symbols of the United Nations and of its member States with respect.

Prohibited:

- Do not discriminate based on age, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, disability, race, ethnicity, nationality, religion, culture, language, financial status or political persuasion.
- Do not dismiss, mock or override another participant's cultural protocols or practices.

2.3 | Standard 3: Preventing Harassment, Bullying & Sexual Misconduct

COY has a zero tolerance policy towards any harassment, bullying or sexual misconduct. This section incorporates the three harassment categories set out in the YOUNGO Code of Conduct (Section 2.1 - Harassment).

2.3.1 Physical harassment - prohibited:

- **Injury:** Injury or hurt to another person's body, individually or as part of a group.
- **Threats:** Actual or threatened violence toward any individual or group, even if intended as a joke.
- **Endangerment:** Endangering the life, safety, health or wellbeing of others.

2.3.2 Mental/psychological harassment - prohibited:

- **Slander or defamation:** tarnishing someone's reputation, or sharing false or private information to affect public opinion of them.
- **Manipulation or coercion:** pressuring someone into something they don't want to do, or taking unfair advantage of them.
- **Discourtesy:** repeated unwanted behaviour, intimidation, or creating a hostile or humiliating environment for another person.

2.3.3 Sexual harassment & sexual misconduct - prohibited:

- **Physical conduct:** any indecent assault, including touching, patting, pinching, stroking, kissing, hugging, fondling or other unwelcome touching, up to and including sexual assault or rape.
- **Verbal conduct:** comments on appearance or private life; sexual insults, comments, stories or jokes; condescending or patronising remarks; repeated unwanted advances (e.g. invitations for dates or physical intimacy); using status, favours or threats to solicit sexual activity.
- **Non-verbal conduct:** displaying sexually explicit or suggestive material; sharing someone's image without authorisation; sexually suggestive gestures, whistling or leering.

2.3.4 Bullying - prohibited:

- Repeated, deliberate behaviour intended to intimidate, exclude, humiliate or harm another person, including online.

2.4 Standard 4: Keeping Each Other Safe

Expected:

- Act responsibly around children and young people - their safety comes first in every interaction.
- Follow all applicable rules and procedures of the event, including any relevant health protocols.
- Cooperate and comply with requests and instructions from YOUNGO, UNFCCC officials and security staff issued in their official capacity regarding the use of facilities and access to and conduct within the venues of the COY event.
- Report a safeguarding concern promptly through the designated channels - don't sit on it, don't try to resolve it yourself.
- Cooperate fully with safeguarding procedures and investigations.
- Support your own and others' wellbeing - take breaks, stay hydrated, speak up if unwell, unsafe, or in need of support.

Prohibited:

- Unsupervised one-to-one contact between an adult and a child in a private space, unless the child’s parent or guardian has provided consent for this to occur.
- Retaliation, intimidation or adverse treatment against anyone who reports a concern in good faith.

2.5 | Standard 5: Alcohol, Drugs & Substance Use

Prohibited:

- Use, possession, distribution of, or requesting, alcohol or illicit drugs at any COY-related setting.
- Attending any session involving children while under the influence of alcohol or drugs.
- Bringing alcohol or drugs into any space where children are present. This includes within the COY organised accommodation.

2.6 Standard 6: Social Media & Digital Conduct

Expected:

- Ask before photographing or filming anyone - respect the lanyard opt-out system.
- Post about COY in a way consistent with these values.

Prohibited:

- Photographing or filming a participant who has opted out (coloured lanyard sticker) or a child without documented consent.
- Taking or sharing another person's image, likeness or personal information without their consent.
- Harassment, discrimination or bullying conducted online, via COY platforms, event hashtags, or personal accounts referencing COY.

2.7 Standard 7: Undue Use of Information

This section is in line with the YOUNGO Code of Conduct (Section 2.2 - Undue Use of Information). It applies principally to organisers, staff, volunteers, Safeguarding Team members, COY Liaisons, YOUNGO Focal Points, YOUNGO Global Coordination Team and YOUNGO Council members, and anyone else holding a COY role with access to confidential information, registration data, or decision-making processes.

Expected:

- Handle information accurately and in good faith; don't deceive, defraud or mislead other participants, UN officials, or external parties COY works with.

Exceptions:

- Disclosing information is not a breach where it's necessary to protect health or safety (e.g. preventing self-harm, alerting to a contagious illness, protecting a child), or where it's given as testimony or evidence in a misconduct investigation.

2.7.1 Privileged or Confidential Information

Prohibited:

- Unauthorised disclosure of confidential information relating to investigations, selection processes, or personnel/participant data, without appropriate consultation.
- Sharing another person's private data or discussions without their consent, or with anyone not party to the original discussion.
- Sharing confidential safeguarding information without authorisation.
- Releasing sensitive or restricted information prematurely where doing so could cause harm (e.g. before an official announcement).
- Sharing passwords or account access for COY/YOUNGO-affiliated email, social media, or shared drives outside agreed access arrangements.

2.7.2 Public Information

Prohibited:

- Treating information that should be publicly available (announcements, opportunities, shared documents) as restricted, or delaying its disclosure in a way that disadvantages others.
- Refusing other participants access to information they need for the event to function (shared drives, mailing lists, communication channels) without good reason.
- Ignoring reasonable requests for explanation where a process or decision is being questioned.

2.8 Standard 8: Function Abuse

This section is in line with the YOUNGO Code of Conduct (Section 2.3 - Function Abuse). It applies principally to anyone holding a formal COY role or mandate - organising committee, team leads, facilitators, Safeguarding Team, volunteers in a supervisory capacity including COY Liaisons, YOUNGO Focal Points, YOUNGO Global Coordination Team and YOUNGO Council members.

Prohibited:

- **Abandonment of function**: deserting a role or responsibility without notice, or stalling processes you're responsible for.

- **Misrepresentation**: claiming to speak or act on behalf of COY or YOUNGO without valid authority, or misrepresenting the scope of your own role.
- **Conflict of interest**: acting in a matter where you have a personal, financial or relational stake without declaring it *(see YOUNGO's Conflict of Interest Policy for full detail.)*
- **Violating your mandate**: acting outside the scope of your assigned role, Focal Point or Liaison mandate, or team guidelines.
- **Corruption and abuse of power**: using your position to influence, pressure or force someone's participation, whether by offering an advantage or by threat; passively accepting or actively offering favours to change a decision or outcome.

2.9 Standard 9: Taking Responsibility for the Bigger Picture

Expected:

- Represent COY and YOUNGO's mission with the ambition and hope we ask of the movement.

PART 3 - SAFEGUARDING POLICY

This Safeguarding Policy sets out the commitments & minimum standards and safeguards COY puts in place to prevent harm and protect everyone attending, with particular regard to children and others who need extra support.

3.1 | Commitment 1: Harassment & Bullying

Commitment: An environment free from harassment and bullying in all forms.

Minimum standards:

- Behavioural expectations communicated to all participants before and during COY (via the Standard of Behaviour).
- Mandatory pre-event training for staff, volunteers, facilitators and anyone in a supervisory role: recognising abuse, bystander intervention, safe online behaviour.
- Voluntary safeguarding training for delegates and speakers/session organisers on the above.
- Bystander intervention guidance made available and actively promoted, not just published.
- COY will promote a culture where reporting concerns is encouraged and supported, where accessible, confidential reporting channels are available (see Safeguarding Procedure).
- Immediate access to confidential support (including medical, psychosocial, and legal referrals) will be offered to those affected, ensuring culturally appropriate services are accessible.
- Early intervention - patterns of low-level bullying are addressed before they escalate, not just responded to after a formal report.

3.2 | Commitment 2: Sexual Misconduct

Commitment: Zero tolerance of any sexual misconduct.

Minimum standards:

- All participants must adhere to the Standard of Behaviour which explicitly prohibits sexual harassment, sexual exploitation, non-consensual sexual activity, inappropriate sexual comments, voyeurism, and any exchange of sexual activity for favours or benefits.

- Where roles involve substantial contact with children or other vulnerable people, COY will carry out appropriate screening measures (reference checks, professional references, and where legally permitted, background checks). Contracts and role descriptions will include safeguarding responsibilities and expectations.
- Event logistics will reduce risk by ensuring visible staffing in public areas, safe check-in/check-out processes, well-lit communal spaces, codes for one-to-one interactions (no unsupervised one-to-one meetings in private spaces), and clear rules for photography, filming, and social media use.
- Immediate access to confidential support (including medical, mental health, and legal referrals) will be offered to survivors, ensuring survivors can access culturally appropriate services in a number of languages and in accessible formats.

3.3 Commitment 3: Child Protection

Commitment: The particular vulnerability and rights of children are recognised and protected in every event activity.

Minimum standards:

- Children's participation requires documented parental or guardian consent. Where children attend as delegates or volunteers, clear information about activities, expected time commitments, communication channels, supervision, and safeguarding measures must be provided to guardians in advance.
- Every child delegate has a registered chaperone with them at all times. Each child is paired with a designated, trained adult mentor as a consistent point of contact who supports wellbeing checks and ensures the child's voice is heard in decisions affecting them.
- Programming involving children will be age-appropriate, trauma-informed, and designed to avoid retraumatisation. Facilitators working with children must have training in child participation and safeguarding.
- For sessions in the programme that are not targeted at children, facilitators should still bear in mind that children may be present or participating, and should keep content, language and material appropriate for a general audience - avoiding anything overly explicit, graphic or distressing that would be fine for an adults-only session but not one children may attend.
- Online communications with children will use approved platforms and channels; staff and volunteers will follow clear guidance on appropriate language, use of images, consent for photography or recordings, and privacy protections. Reminders about appropriate and

safe communication and the Standard of Behaviour and Safeguarding Policy will be regularly shared by the COY team and volunteers.

- Adults chaperoning children must complete the safeguarding training; unsupervised one-to-one adult-child contact is structurally prevented (open doors, visible spaces, third-party presence).
- Photography opt-out system: coloured lanyard sticker for anyone (child or adult) who doesn't want to be photographed/filmed; online participants may keep camera/mic off at any time.
- The Safeguarding Team on-ground will include at least one trained in mental health first aid, physical first aid, children's wellbeing, cross-cultural work, and local emergency procedures.
- The Safeguarding Team ensures fair, equal distribution of food and water (including dietary requirements) and builds in adequate breaks for rest and mental health.
- Children's personal data, along with the personal data of all COY attendees is stored on a password-protected system and deleted within a maximum of 4 weeks of the event ending.
- Any child protection concern must be reported immediately through the Safeguarding Procedure. COY will promptly implement protective actions and, where required, refer matters to relevant child protection authorities or specialist agencies in line with local law and the child's best interests.

3.4 Commitment 4: Cultural Safety

Commitment: Every participant's cultural identity and protocols are respected and actively accommodated, not just tolerated.

Minimum standards:

- Acknowledgement of Country/traditional custodians (or local equivalent) built into event opening as culturally appropriate.
- Interpretation/translation support and multilingual materials for key safeguarding information (reporting channels, Standard of Behaviour, emergency procedures).
- Culturally appropriate referral pathways for support and police services - not a single default provider assumed to suit everyone, and acknowledgement of different cultural and lived experiences with authorities.
- Dietary, religious and cultural practices accommodated in catering and scheduling (e.g. prayer breaks, fasting considerations).

- Programming and facilitation designed with cultural safety advisors where the delegate cohort warrants it.

3.5 Commitment 5: Discrimination, Equality & Inclusiveness

Commitment: An environment where diversity is valued and unequal treatment based on a protected characteristic doesn't occur.

Minimum standards:

- Accessible venues and facilities (physical access, gender-neutral facilities where possible).
- Equitable speaking and leadership opportunities across delegates.
- Non-discriminatory, transparent selection processes for delegate places, speaking slots and roles.
- Accommodations for disability arranged proactively (not only on request) - captioning, accessible seating and venue layout, sensory-friendly spaces.

3.6 Commitment 6: Mental Health, Wellbeing & Psychosocial Safety

Commitment: The psychosocial wellbeing of participants is treated as core safeguarding, not an add-on.

Minimum standards:

- A designated welfare/quiet space available throughout the event for anyone needing a mental, emotional or physical break.
- At least one member of the Safeguarding Team members trained in mental health first aid.
- Programming builds in breaks for rest and mental health, not just meals.
- Trauma-informed and professional facilitation only for sessions covering distressing content (e.g. climate grief, personal testimony) - content warnings, opt-out options, debrief availability.
- No one is pressured to disclose, participate, or resume an activity before they're ready.
- Psychosocial support and referral is a standard part of the response to any safeguarding concern, not something offered only on request.
- Confidentiality of any health or wellbeing disclosure is protected.

3.7 | Commitment 7: Heat, Dehydration & Fatigue Management

Commitment: Prevent heat-related illness, dehydration and excessive fatigue, with particular consideration for minors and others needing additional support.

Minimum standards:

- Safe drinking water accessible throughout the conference, including during outdoor activities and movement between venues.
- Shaded/cool rest areas identified in advance; outdoor activities scheduled to avoid peak heat where possible; adequate ventilation/cooling indoors.
- Regular breaks built into the programme; no unnecessarily long sessions; seating provided at queues; no unnecessary late-night activities involving participants.
- Weather-appropriate clothing and sun protection encouraged.
- Safeguarding and Logistics teams monitor conditions actively (not just reactively) — see risk matrix below.

3.8 | Commitment 8: First Aid

Commitment: Rapid, appropriately-trained medical response is available throughout the event, coordinated with (not separate from) safeguarding.

Minimum standards:

- A Medical/First Aid Team present and clearly signed throughout the event; locations known to all staff and volunteers.
- Any injury, illness, heat/dehydration incident, or medical dimension of a safeguarding concern goes through First Aid and the Safeguarding Focal Point simultaneously - one team doesn't act without the other being aware.
- Emergency contacts and nearest health facility documented and accessible to all relevant staff.
- Where a participant discloses a relevant medical condition or allergy in advance, this is recorded securely and accessible to First Aid on a need-to-know basis, with the participant's consent.

3.9 | Commitment 9: Alcohol & Drug Use

Commitment: Maintain zero tolerance for alcohol and illicit drug use.

Minimum standards:

- Alcohol and illicit drug use, possession, distribution or solicitation is treated as a serious breach with potential police/authority referral.
- Staff and volunteers working directly with children are not under the influence of alcohol or drugs at any point during their duties.

PART 4 - SAFEGUARDING PROCEDURE

> **This Safeguarding Procedure sets out how COY prevents, reports, responds, and follows up on any safeguarding concern raised under the Safeguarding Policy and Standard of Behaviour - the reporting channels, risk assessment, investigation steps, and support measures that put COY's commitments into practice.**

4.1 Prevent

The systems and preparations in place before a concern arises.

4.1.1 Event Safeguarding Risk Assessment

A safeguarding risk assessment of the event and venue is conducted before COY begins, covering:

- **Physical layout** - sightlines, isolated or unsupervised areas, lighting, access points, proximity of alcohol-serving areas to child-facing spaces.
- **Venue-specific hazards** - heat/ventilation conditions, outdoor exposure, evacuation routes, distance to nearest medical facility.
- **Local context** - relevant local laws, emergency services, child protection authorities, and cultural considerations specific to the location.
- **Staffing and supervision gaps** - whether planned Safeguarding/CES/First Aid coverage is sufficient for the venue's size and layout.

Findings feed directly into the pre-event checklist below and into any venue-specific adjustments.

4.1.2 Pre-Event Checklist

Pre-Event Checklist, including but not limited to:

- Drinking water accessible
- Shade/rest areas identified
- First aid staffed and signed
- Emergency contacts accessible to relevant staff
- Safeguarding Focal Points identified, trained and visible
- All volunteers, organising team members and contractors briefed on safeguarding and welfare
- Breaks built into the programme
- Ventilation/cooling adequate indoors
- Child supervision and chaperone arrangements confirmed

- Welfare/quiet space identified
- Reporting mechanism (QR code/form/phone number) live and tested
- Emergency/transport referral pathway confirmed

4.1.3 Pre-COY Communications

- Reporting channels, the Standard of Behaviour, and this Procedure are communicated to all participants before and throughout the event - pre-event comms, on-site signage, and a verbal briefing at the start of each session.
- Anyone with managerial or supervisory responsibility ensures their own team is briefed before the event starts.

4.1.4 Training

- Mandatory pre-event training for all staff, volunteers, facilitators, and anyone in a supervisory or child-facing role - covering recognising abuse, bystander intervention, cultural safety, safe online behaviour, and this Procedure's reporting and triage process.
- Safeguarding training is also made available to attendees and session organisers who want it, on a voluntary basis, so participation in a safe event isn't limited to those in a formal role.
- Completion of mandatory training is tracked and confirmed before a staff/volunteer role begins.

4.1.5 Safeguarding Team

Before being confirmed in a Safeguarding Team or other child-facing or supervisory role, individuals complete:

- A **Working With Children Check** (or local jurisdictional equivalent), verified as current and valid.
- Reference checks confirming suitability for a safeguarding or child-facing role.
- A background check, where legally permitted in the relevant jurisdiction.
- A declaration of any conflict of interest relevant to safeguarding responsibilities.

4.2 Report

Recognising and identifying a concern and providing reporting channels.

4.2.1 Who Can Report

- Any participant, volunteer, staff member, speaker, moderator, contractor, partner, sponsor, or visitor.

- Anyone who witnesses, experiences, or reasonably suspects misconduct or a safeguarding risk.
- Anyone reporting on behalf of another person, where there is reasonable belief that person is unable or unwilling to report themselves.

4.1.2 What to Report

The following concerns should be reported immediately:

- Harassment or bullying.
- Sexual harassment, sexual exploitation, or sexual abuse.
- Physical, emotional, or psychological abuse.
- Child safeguarding concerns.
- Discrimination or hate-related behaviour.
- Any other breach of the COY Standard of Behaviour that may place a person at risk.

Reports made in good faith are encouraged even where there is no conclusive evidence.

4.1.3 Who to Report to

- **Safeguarding Team:** Identifiable on-site by badge/lanyard, so anyone can find a team member quickly without needing to know names in advance.
- **Focal Points / Liaisons:** May receive a report directly, but will pass it on to the wider Safeguarding Team, unless doing so would itself create a conflict of interest (e.g. the concern involves that Focal Point / Liaison or Safeguarding team member) in which they must ensure that those individuals are not made aware of the matter.
- **COY Organising Team:** If a report is made to any other member of the COY Organising Team, they will pass this onto the Safeguarding Team, taking note of any concerns around specific individuals having a perceived or actual conflict of interest, ensuring that those individuals are not informed of the matter.

4.1.4 Reporting Channels

- A designated Safeguarding Team, named and visible on-site.
- An official safeguarding email address.
- An official and confidential safeguarding and wellbeing phone number on whatsapp, with local sim card for ensuring emergency services can be directly contacted and location tracked.
- A confidential online reporting form (QR code on every lanyard).
- An emergency, in-person contact available throughout conference hours.

- In-person to any Safeguarding Team member, for child-related concerns.

Channels are communicated before and throughout the event (pre-event comms, safeguarding training, on-site signage, and verbal briefing at the start of each session) including phone number, email, and how to identify safeguarding personnel on the ground.

4.1.5 Confidentiality

- **Confidential handling** - all safeguarding reports, records and related information are handled with strict confidentiality, shared only with those with a legitimate role in receiving, assessing, investigating or responding, **on a strict need-to-know basis**.
- **Protection of personal data** - personal information is collected, stored, accessed and processed securely, and only for safeguarding purposes.
- **Respect for privacy** - the privacy, dignity and identity of complainants, witnesses and respondents are protected throughout; personal information is not disclosed publicly unless legally required or necessary to prevent serious harm.
- **Confidentiality obligations** - all organisers, volunteers and staff involved in handling a concern must maintain confidentiality during and after the process. Unauthorised disclosure is itself a breach.
- **Secure record management** - records are stored securely, access limited to authorised personnel, and retained only as long as necessary for safeguarding, legal or organisational obligations. Children's data is deleted within 2 weeks of the event.

4.1.6 Protection Against Retaliation

No person suffers retaliation, intimidation, discrimination, or adverse treatment for reporting in good faith or cooperating with a safeguarding process. Retaliation is itself a breach of the Standard of Behaviour and may result in disciplinary action.

4.3 Respond

What happens once a concern is identified and rated.

4.3.1 General response sequence

- **Acknowledge** the concern as soon as reasonably possible. Safety, dignity and wellbeing of the affected person remain the priority throughout.
- **Preliminary Assessment:** whether immediate risk is identified, apply immediate safety measures where relevant (risk rating 2-4 High to Critical/Emergency).
- **Rate** the risk of the concern to identify the appropriate level and type of response.
- **Assessment:** A designated safeguarding representative conducts a preliminary assessment (confirming scope and whether enough information exists to proceed) without unnecessary interviews.

- **Investigate:** Where a formal investigation is required, it's conducted by two members of the Safeguarding Team who are tasked with ensuring the investigation is fair, evidence-based, free of conflict of interest, and that all parties are treated with respect.
- **Document:** All reports, interviews, evidence and decisions are recorded accurately and stored securely; access limited to authorised individuals with a legitimate need to know.
- **Outcome & follow-up**: Proportionate action is taken based on findings; referral to competent authorities where appropriate; follow-up support offered to affected individuals wherever possible.

4.3.2 Immediate safety measures

Where there is immediate risk, the COY Organising Team may take temporary protective measures before any investigation concludes - separating individuals, restricting activity access, contacting emergency services, or referring to protection services. These measures are precautionary and do not imply that responsibility has been established.

4.3.3 Risk Rating & Triage

Every report is triaged into one of four tiers on receipt. This keeps the response proportionate and fast, and ensures the same urgent process applies whether the concern came in through the form, in person, or via a witness.

Tier	Examples	Timeframe
1 - Low (wellbeing check)	Minor interpersonal friction, first-time low-level Code breach, mild fatigue/thirst	Same day
2 - Moderate	Discrimination, cultural safety breach, persistent unwanted behaviour, heat exhaustion, emerging bullying pattern	Acknowledge ≤2 hrs; resolve ≤48 hrs
3 - High	Harassment/bullying pattern, sexual misconduct allegation, missing/unsupervised child, suspected heatstroke, online harassment	Immediate response; investigation ≤48 hrs
4 - Critical/Emergency	Sexual assault, violence, life-threatening medical emergency, immediate danger to a child	Immediate

4.3.3 Concern-Specific Response Protocols

Concern	Protocol

Heat, dehydration & fatigue	Heat, Dehydration& Fatigue Management Plan
Child-specific incident (including missing or unsupervised child)	Child & Minor Protection Plan
Mental health or psychosocial concern	Mental Health or Psychosocial Concern
Alcohol or drug incident	Alcohol or Drug Incident
Online harassment or confidentiality/data breach	Online Harassment or Confidentiality/Data Breach

4.4 Follow-up

What happens after the immediate response.

4.4.1 Outcome & follow-up support

Proportionate action is taken based on findings and follow-up support offered to affected individuals wherever possible.

4.4.2 Consequences of Violations

- **Zero-tolerance approach** - COY adopts a zero-tolerance approach toward harassment, sexual misconduct, abuse, exploitation, discrimination, retaliation, and any breach of this Safeguarding Policy & Procedure. Every allegation shall be assessed fairly and appropriately, regardless of the position or role of the individual concerned.
- **Disciplinary measures** - Where a violation of this policy is substantiated, COY may take appropriate disciplinary or administrative action proportionate to the seriousness of the misconduct. Measures may include:
    - Formal warning.
    - Removal from specific activities or responsibilities.
    - Suspension or termination of volunteer or staff roles.
    - Removal from the conference or related activities.
- **Referral to competent authorities** - Where the reported conduct may constitute a criminal offence or where required by applicable law, COY may refer the matter to the appropriate national authorities while respecting the rights, safety, and confidentiality of those involved.
- **Compliance obligations** - Failure to comply may result in temporary suspension from activities, removal from the event or termination of a role or contract.

- **False or malicious reports** - Reports made in good faith shall never result in disciplinary action, even if they are not substantiated. However, intentionally false or malicious reports submitted with the purpose of causing harm may themselves constitute misconduct and may be subject to appropriate action.
- **YOUNGO-level sanctions** - Where the same conduct also breaches the YOUNGO Code of Conduct, YOUNGO's own sanctions may apply independently of any COY consequence above.
- **Non-retaliation** - Retaliation against a good-faith reporter, or against anyone participating in an investigation, is treated as a serious breach.
- **Continued commitment to Safeguarding -** Any action taken under this policy shall aim not only to address misconduct but also to strengthen accountability, maintain trust, and promote a safe, respectful, and inclusive environment for all participants.

4.4.3 Reporting COY Safeguarding Outcomes to YOUNGO and necessary external authorities

Secure, confidential safeguarding incident records will be maintained in line with Australian and Turkish privacy law. The Safeguarding Team will prepare a de-identified summary report after the event, which will be shared with:

- **Child & Youth Pavilion:** where relevant to a safeguarding matter or shared programming space that may be relevant to the safe, respectful and inclusive environment of the Child & Youth Pavilion.
- **YOUNGO:** to support lessons learned and safeguarding improvements for future events and to follow up or further investigate relevant safeguarding incidents, provided that explicit consent and confidentiality agreements are made with the victim(s).
- **UNFCCC and/or the host country:** where relevant to conduct occurring within official UNFCCC premises or sessions.

In practice, reporters will be able to opt-in to consenting to their information being included in the summary report. Where information is shared onward with consent, it's shared in the least identifying form necessary for the stated purpose (e.g. an anonymised pattern for "lessons learned" doesn't need names attached).